



Keep in mind that while these devices are relatively secure, there's still nothing like total security; at best they provide a deterrent.

Secure the insides

Corporate espionage is a growing problem; the data on your machine may of immense value to the competition. Even ordinary e-mail can be a source of information. Your only shield here is making sure that the computer cannot be accessed by anyone but yourself, and that the data is still unreadable, should someone try to swap drives—BIOS and Windows passwords are not adequate security. Use a relatively more secure OS such as Windows 2000 or Windows XP, and patch the OS with the latest service packs. Then use commercial tools to further secure and limit access. To this end, we tested SafeBoot Solo.

To run this tool, you'll need a Windows-based laptop and formatted floppy diskettes. You'll be prompted to create rescue diskettes at installation, which can be used to recover from hard drive failure, or from a corrupted setup. These diskettes can be used to log in to your machine, so store them securely.

SafeBoot Solo

SafeBoot Solo (www.safeboot.com) is simple, easy to use and is shareware—after the trial period expires, SafeBoot will delay boot-up by a minute. Installing SafeBoot is a two-step process—installation and configuration. Once SafeBoot is installed, you are prompted to reboot, after which a simple configuration process starts. You'll be prompted to enter a username and password, which you will use to authenticate, as well as change SafeBoot's settings. Now you can opt to encrypt all, or some of your drives—you can choose either partial or complete encryption. A partially encrypted drive has 10 per cent of its drive volume encrypted. Ideally, encrypt the entire drive. After this, the installer starts copying all the additional setup files.

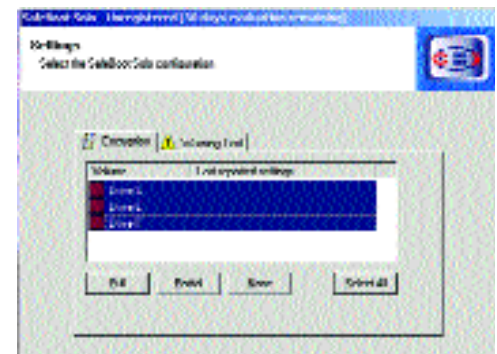
If you chose to encrypt drives, SafeBoot will conduct the drive encryption operation imme-

diately. You can choose to either reboot, or continue working with SafeBoot in the background; you can also stop and restart it later. To view the encryption status, just right-click on the SafeBoot icon and choose Show Status.

With SafeBoot installed, you are presented with a login screen when the computer is turned on. On the login screen, you'll find additional options to boot from either hard drive or floppy. Once you authenticate, Windows boots up normally.

While you work with Windows, double-clicking the SafeBoot icon in the system tray launches your screensaver and locks your computer. You need to re-enter your Windows password to continue working.

While SafeBoot forces you to authenticate before Windows loads up, you should encrypt your hard drives to safeguard your data. This will prevent someone from just removing your hard drive and reading your data on another laptop. SafeBoot's encryption works on a real-time basis—files read from an encrypted drive are encrypted and decrypted on the fly. SafeBoot uses the AES algorithm



Encrypting drives using SafeBoot

(the Advanced Encryption Standard) implemented with 256-bit security. If you didn't encrypt your drives during installation, you can do so by right-clicking on the SafeBoot icon in the system tray and choosing Configure. You will also be prompted to re-use the rescue disk you created earlier.